

GALLEY WARFARE

THE BATTLE OF LEPANTO

Fought off the coast of Greece on 7 October 1571, the Battle of Lepanto was the climax of the era of galley warfare in the Mediterranean. More than 400 oared warships engaged in a close-fought battle that resulted in one of Christian Europe's greatest victories over the Ottoman Turks.

In the 16th century, Muslim naval forces – the well-funded fleet of the Ottoman Empire, and the piratical Barbary corsairs from the ports of North Africa – were bidding for control of the Mediterranean. The states of Christian Europe were rarely capable of uniting to face this threat; however, in 1571, they forged a Holy League to resist an Ottoman attack on Cyprus. The combined fleets of Habsburg Spain, Venice, Genoa, the Papacy, Savoy, and the Knights of St John were led by Don John of Austria, illegitimate half-brother of Philip II of Spain. Heading into the eastern Mediterranean, they met the Ottoman fleet and its corsair allies in the Gulf of Patras.

The galleys carried large contingents of soldiers, but their use of equipment showed a clear division of technology and approach. The Christian forces were mostly armoured and carrying arquebuses, while the Muslims were more lightly clad and equipped with composite bows. Galley battles had traditionally involved engaging enemy ships so that soldiers could board and attack at close quarters. But now the Christian fleet also depended heavily on the firepower of naval guns: their galleys had cannon in the bows, and smaller swivel guns to sweep an enemy's deck. They had also rebuilt six large Venetian cargo ships as "galleasses" – unwieldy gun platforms heavily armed with cannon, which had to be assisted into action in front of their fleet. The Muslim galleys, meanwhile, were smaller and lighter, and depended on speed of manoeuvre to gain advantage; on the Christian side, only the Venetian galleys, oared by free men, could

move just as nimbly. The rest of Don John's galleys, heavy with cannon and clumsily rowed by prisoners and slaves, kept in line abreast, to protect their flanks and maximize the power of their forward-firing guns.

JOINING THE FRAY

Commanded by Ali Pasha from the flagship *Sultana*, the Ottomans and corsairs took the initiative. They advanced in crescent formation, attempting to outflank the Venetians on their left, and the Genoese on their right. The Ottoman centre came under bombardment from the galleasses, causing damage to the ships. Ali Pasha, undeterred, pressed forward towards Don John's flagship *Real* at the heart of the Christian fleet. Soon galleys were locked together in deadly combat, soldiers fighting hand-to-hand on the decks. The Genoese were outflanked by corsair captain Uluj Ali, who threatened to break through on the Christian right. On the left, the Venetian commander Agostino Barbarigo was killed by an arrow in the eye, while in the centre Ottoman Janissaries boarded *Real*.

The Christians were saved by the experienced Habsburg admiral Álvaro de Bazán. Leading a reserve force of galleys, he directed ships into the battle at crucial moments, shoring up the flanks and rescuing Don John's flagship. The turning point came when Ali Pasha's flagship *Sultana* was boarded and taken, and his severed head displayed on a pike. The Muslim fleet disintegrated, with only Uluj Ali succeeding in rescuing his ships from the rout.

